

Skype, for instance, uses its own proprietary technology to make sure that voice reaches you fast and clearly.

Why it's "evil":

Several governments, including our own, already hate VoIP for robbing the telecom sector of all the money they could make on international calls. But that's hardly the point. The real problem with VoIP is that it's considerably more secure than cell phones. Calls made from VoIP phones can only be traced to the point where they get converted from regular voice data to Internet data. Once the data enters the Internet, it bounces around servers across the globe before it reaches its destination. Worse, even if you find out which number the call was made to, determining its position can be a pain. The recipient of a call could have a New York phone number, but could still be in the room next to the caller, which is why terrorists seem to love it.

For a few years now, the FBI has been issuing warnings that militants have been using

Fighting it

While VoIP calls are difficult to trace and tap, they aren't impossible. Unfortunately, these can be time-consuming processes, and in a situation like Mumbai, we can't afford that time. To make its job easier, the FBI is pushing for a law that will require VoIP service providers to build backdoors in their software, which law enforcement agencies can use to tap calls when necessary. The same laws already exist for telecom providers since 1994, when the FBI's surveillance activities were thwarted by new technologies like call forwarding and cell phones.

The only good thing that emerged from the terrorists using VoIP phones was that the digital trail could potentially lead the authorities to their handlers. If the group was more reluctant to use phones while they conducted the attacks, the trail would have ended at the last terrorist alive.

VoIP for their activities, and a report in October last year highlighted that the Taliban was using Skype to keep in touch. The problem? To ensure that your voice calls aren't overheard, VoIP providers build secure, proprietary technologies that make it very difficult for hackers to eavesdrop on your calls. Naturally, it also becomes difficult for the law to tap these calls.

Waking Up

With prior terrorist attacks, finding the perpetrators was a matter of some old-fashioned police work. It was slow, but let's admit it — a few days after the blasts, it was only the police who were frustrated. We just returned to our daily lives — a little rattled, but our shock swiftly gave way to the stress of everyday existence. These attacks, however, were different. For three days, we sat glued to our TVs, horrified, helpless, frustrated, angry, imprisoned. After watching so many movies and shows where the good guys use sophisticated technology to overcome terrorists in minutes, we were shocked that our police force was so ill-equipped. While the terrorists knew the hotels in intimate detail, our forces didn't even have night vision goggles to navigate the dark corridors. While the terrorists kept in touch with each other and their handlers using cell phones and VoIP, our forces didn't even use walkie-talkies to coordinate their counter-attack. The snipers stationed outside the Taj couldn't open fire, because they couldn't tell whether they were looking at terrorists or hostages. Because their rifles didn't have telescopes.

If you've played "realistic" games like *Counter-strike* and *Rainbow Six*, you probably thought that you and your clan could have done a better job with the situation. Quite likely, but you'd have to consider that you'd be using real guns, and there's no starting from a save point. But we digress.

Now, home minister P. Chidambaram has announced a massive overhaul of our security system, though we still don't have details on what that will be. We are assuming (and hoping) that this overhaul includes updating our forces' tools, and training them on all the technology they'll need to take down any terrorists. As for the technologies themselves, the debate still rages.

Even if you were to believe that technology was the villain here, where do we go from here? Will we see bans on mobile phones and GPS receivers? We must face the fact that even innocuous, everyday technology can be used for malicious purposes, and focus instead on using that same technology against the terrorists. ■

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page
103

Open source terrorism

The Mumbai attacks are part of a disturbing trend that experts are calling open-source warfare. Unfortunately, it doesn't mean that terrorists are releasing their plans to the public — they're using technology and the philosophies of open source software to wreak havoc. The scary thing about this scenario is that terrorist outfits needn't start with the big organisations like the Al Qaeda — all it takes is a single terrorist.

The open source philosophy: release often, even if the software is buggy
The terrorists' corruption: attack often, even if there isn't a concrete plan

The open source philosophy: recruit as many developers as possible
The terrorists' corruption: recruit as many "warriors" as possible

The open source philosophy: use solutions that have worked with other projects
The terrorists' corruption: find out how other outfits are bypassing security